

How can we perform generic conditional synchronization with semaphores in a similar (and simple) way as condition variables?

To achieve this behavior we should separate two different scenarios:

(1) There is no difference in the waiting active entities, meaning that any one can be the successful target of the signaling process (eg. insert/remove element from a queue). In this simpler scenario, since semaphores are (special!) counting (shared) variables, we can achieve the desired equivalence by using "trick" of counting the number of waiting active entities. This solution works because the use of conditional synchronization semaphore (cvar_id) only when *cvar_waiters is positive; and *cvar_waiters is positive only when the condition is not met. In this case, there is no need to use broadcast instead of signal. If a separated conditional synchronization semaphore is used for each condition (as we should do, also with condition variables), then no broadcast is required (a signal is enough).

MUTEX & CONDITION VARIABLES	SHARED MEMORY & SEMAPHORES
// INITIALIZATION:	
<pre>// mutex: pthread_mutex_t mtx; mutex_init(&mtx, NULL); // condition variable: pthread_cond_t cvar; cond_init(&cvar, NULL);</pre>	<pre>// Binary semaphore with initial value 1: int mtx_id = psemget(semkey, 1, 0600 IPC_CREAT IPC_EXCL); psem_up(mtx_id, 0); // Integer semaphore with initial value 0: int cvar_id = psemget(key, 1, 0600 IPC_CREAT IPC_EXCL); // Shared integer variable (in shared memory!): int shmid = pshmget(shmkey, sizeof(int), 0600 IPC_CREAT IPC_EXCL); int* cvar_waiters = pshmat(shmid, NULL, 0); // before fork(s) *cvar_waiters = 0; ... pshmdt(cvar_waiters); // at the end, after all wait[pid]</pre>
// WAIT:	
<pre>mutex_lock(&mtx); while (!condition) { cond_wait(&cvar, &mtx); } ... mutex_unlock(&mtx);</pre>	<pre>// wait (assumes cvar_waiters attached): psem_down(mtx_id, 0); // lock while (!condition) { (*cvar_waiters)++; psem_up(mtx_id, 0); // unlock psem_down(cvar_id, 0); // wait psem_down(mtx_id, 0); // lock } ... psem_up(mtx_id, 0); // unlock</pre>
// SIGNAL:	
<pre>mutex_lock(&mtx); ... cond_signal(&cvar); mutex_unlock(&mtx);</pre>	<pre>// signal (assumes cvar_waiters attached): psem_down(mtx_id, 0); // lock ... if ((*cvar_waiters) > 0) { psem_up(cvar_id, 0); // signal one (*cvar_waiters)--; } psem_up(mtx_id, 0); // unlock</pre>
// BROADCAST:	
<pre>mutex_lock(&mtx); ... cond_broadcast(&cvar); mutex_unlock(&mtx);</pre>	<pre>// broadcast (assumes cvar_waiters attached): psem_down(mtx_id, 0); // lock ... while ((*cvar_waiters) > 0) { psem_up(cvar_id, 0); // signal one (*cvar_waiters)--; } psem_up(mtx_id, 0); // unlock</pre>

(2) When the waiting active entities might not all be applicable to a signal (eg. withdraw money from a shared account), then the previous implementation might fail. The problem arises because the same active entity might respond twice (or more times) to the same broadcast (no control there, because we have only a cvar waiting counter); thus preventing one waiting active entity to respond to a broadcast. In this case, a different more complex alternative is required (not presented here because it will not be required for this course).